Let's Pretend This Never Happened

By Jenny Lawson

(From the Chapter Jenkins, You Mother F**, Pg 43-53)**

When I was little, my mother used to say that I **<was>** "nervous."

Most children didn't hyperventilate when asked to leave the house. My teachers whispered "neurotic." But deep down I knew there was a better word for what I was. *Doomed.*

Doomed because I couldn't give a speech in class without breaking into uncontrollable hysterical laughter. Doomed because I knew, without a shadow of a doubt, that something horrible and nameless was going to happen and that I was helpless to stop it.

INTRODUCTION

Author Jenny Lawson had an over-eccentric, anxiety-causing father who would never-endingly bring into her life a circus of animals, people, and Avis (Latin for Birds). She recounts a story from third grade that put her on the road to self-confidence. Her advice to all of us? You never know who or what might teach you a valuable lesson.

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When I was in third grade, my father rushed inside one night to tell us all to come out and look at what he had in the back of his pickup. I was young, but still well trained enough to know that nothing good could come of this.

My mother peered guardedly to see whether anything large was moving in my father's truck. It was. She gave us a look that my father always seemed to interpret as "How lucky you girls are to have such an adventurous father," but which I always read as "One of you will probably not survive your father's enthusiasm."

Usually when my father wanted us to come outside to see what was in the bed of his truck, it was only because whatever was in there was either too bloody and/or vicious for him to carry inside, so we all stayed in the relative safety of our house and asked a series of questions designed to indicate the level of danger of whatever Daddy would be exposing us to.

My Father was perpetually disappointed by our lack of trust.

My mother braced herself with a deep breath and leaned forward to uneasily to stare into the eyes of a dozen grim live birds. A few squawked indignantly, but most

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huddled numbly in the corner, no doubt shell-shocked from the windblown journey, coupled with being forced to share the pickup bed with several animal carcasses my father had probably picked up for taxidermy work. To the birds I assume it must've been very much like accepting a ride from a stranger, only to get in the back of the van to find several murdered hikers who were being made into lamp shades.

My father explained that the birds were well-behaved Wisconsin jumbo quail, and my mother countered that the birds were, in fact, rowdy turkeys.

Those birds loved my father with a white-hot passion.

As the months wore on, the turkeys grew bigger and louder and more obnoxious, and would roost on low tree branches, screaming at my mother every time she left the house. My father insisted that the quails were just eccentric, and that we were misinterpreting the loud, angry gobbling, which he maintained was simply the birds singing with joy.

My father insisted on naming the turkeys and treating them like pets. Pets who would angrily run at you in full-out attack, nipping at your tiny ankles as you ran in circles

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around the yard, screaming for someone to open the door to the house and let you in.

We lived on a rural route, so our mailman was fairly used to being besieged by stray dogs, but he'd been utterly unprepared for an angry turkey attack.

My father lifted the large bird off the hood <of his mail truck>, and tucked him under his arm, saying "Sir, this bird is a *quail*. And his name is Jenkins."

I was not surprised when we found a note in our mailbox, informing us that all further packages would be left by the mailbox rather than being delivered to the door. This was upsetting to my mother, because the mailman's idea of leaving packages at the mailbox was him flinging our mail in the general direction of the house. The turkeys adapted to this by quickly gathering up the mail in the yard, which would have been helpful if they'd brought it to the house like a dog, but instead they'd carry the letters around proudly, as if they were important turkey documents that my mother was attempting to steal from them.

My sister and I began putting together a defensive strategy to protect us from bird assault.

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Lisa and I attempted to fashion ankle armor out of empty soup cans that we'd opened on both sides, but my feet were too big to fit into them, and Lisa's feet were so little that when she ran, the tin cans would clink loudly together and simply attract the attention of the vicious herd. She was basically like a tiny, pigtailed dinner bell. I considered telling her that the ankle armor wasn't helping, but that was tantamount to telling a fellow zebra that he's covered in steak sauce right before you both have to cross a parking lot full of loins. Self-preservation is a narcissistic bedfellow.

Occasionally the turkeys would follow us, menacingly, on our quarter-mile walk to school, lurking behind us like improbable gang members. Even at age nine I was painfully self-conscious, and was aware that dysfunctional pet turkeys would not be viewed as "cool," so I would always duck inside the school-house as quickly as possible and feign ignorance, conspicuously asking my classmates why there were always jumbo quail on the playground.

This worked perfectly until the morning when I ducked inside the school lobby a little to sluggishly, and Jenkins blithely followed me in, gobbling to himself and looking

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both clueless and vaguely threatening. Two other turkeys followed behind Jenkins. I quickly ran into my classroom as the turkeys wandered aimlessly into the library. I sighed in relief that no one had noticed the turkey expedition, until an hour later, and we discovered that the principal and librarian had found the turkeys. They had managed to *shit <Poop> everywhere*. It was actually a little bit impressive, and also horribly revolting. The principal had seen the turkeys follow us to school before, so he called my father and demanded that he come to the school to clean up the mess. My father explained to the principal that he must be mistaken, because he was raising jumbo quail, but the principal wasn't buying it.

A half-hour later, when my class lined up to go to PE, I found my father on his knees, cleaning up poop. He was unsuccessfully attempting to shoo the turkeys away, forcefully yelling, "GO HOME, JENKINS."

I froze, but it was too late. Jenkins recognized me immediately and ran up to me, gobbling with excited recognition like, "OH MY GOD, ISN'T THIS AWESOME? WHO ARE YOUR FRIENDS?"

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And for the first time I didn't run screaming from him. Instead I sighed and waved weakly, mumbling dejectedly, "Hey, Jenkins," as my classmates stared at me in amazement. But not the *good* kind of amazement, it was more of the *bad* kind of amazement. Like when you realize that not having the right kind of leg warmers is really small potatoes compared to being assaulted by an overexcited turkey named Jenkins. I think this was the point when I realized that I was kind of *doomed* when it came to ever becoming the most popular kid in the class, and so I just nodded to Jenkins and my father, and I held my head up high as I walked down the hall and tried not to slip in the feces.

All the rest of that day I waited for the taunting to come, but it never did. It was pretty obvious there was no way to turn me into a "normal" third-grader.

And actually? <I was> a little relieved too. Because it was the first time in my life that I gave myself permission to be me. I was still shy and self-conscious and terrified of people, but Jenkins had essentially freed me of the bonds of having to try to fit in.

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Soon afterward, Jenkins and the other turkeys disappeared from our lives, but the lessons I learned from them sill remain: Turkeys make terrible pets, you should never trust your father to identify poultry, and you should accept who you are, *flaws and all*, because if you try to be someone you aren't, then eventually some turkey is going to *poop* all over your well-crafted façade, so you might as well save yourself the effort. And so I guess, in a way, I owe Jenkins a debt of gratitude, because (even if it was entirely unintentional) he was a brilliant teacher.

And also? *Totally delicious.*

NOTE: <> Bracketed words are added as transition words by editor

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AWARD HISTORY

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